Lecture 11
Early Days of Bangladesh: Challenges and Prospects

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Guest speaker

OUTLINE: LECTURE 13

Early days of Bangladesh: Challenges and Prospects

Learning Objectives:

- **Understand the conditions of the war-ravaged country**
- **Analyze the challenges of rebuilding the country**
- **Explain the four basic principles of the Constitution and the reasons for their inclusion**
- **Describe the salient features of the Constitution (1972)**
- **Identify some of the major Amendments to the Constitution**

TRIUMPHAL HOMECOMING

- **One of the momentous event of 1971 was the emergence of the new state, Bangladesh**
- **The birth of Bangladesh was in many ways a unique phenomenon, for it was the first country to emerge out of a successful national liberation movement waged against "internal colonialism" in post-colonial states like Pakistan**
- **Soon after 16 December 1971, the Bangladesh government-in-exile came back to Dhaka and established itself**

TRIUMPHAL HOMECOMING

- **The year 1972 started with the good news of Bangabandhu's imminent release**
- **On 8 January Bangabandhu Sheikh Mujibur Rahman was released from a Pakistani prison and flown to London from where he returned to Bangladesh at 2:30 p.m. on 10 January**
- **The tumultuous welcome he received from the populace was unprecedented**
- ***See, the conqu'ring hero comes!***

  Sound the trumpets! Beat the drums! **- Handel**

TRIUMPHAL HOMECOMING



Bangabandhu Sheikh Mujibur Rahman acknowledging the reception of a huge gathering of followers upon his landing at the Tejgaon Airport (10 January 1972)



During Bangabandhu Sheikh Mujibur Rahman's homecoming, an overwhelmingly emotional environment is created. Mother of the Nation Sheikh Fazilatunnesa Mujib embraces her husband and his nephew Sheikh Fazlul Hoque Moni adoringly pats his head (10 January 1972)

CHALLENGES OF NATION BUILDING

- **The struggle for the independence of Bangladesh had been arduous and Bangabandhu personally paid a heavy price for leading the people to emancipation and freedom**
- **He had spent more than eleven years in Pakistani prisons and had barely escaped the gallows**
- **A huge challenge confronted him: how to transform a liberated Bangladesh in ruins into a *Sonar Bangla* of his dreams**

CHALLENGES OF NATION BUILDING

- **Even without the massive destruction of 1971, Bangladesh would have been an intolerably poor land, the result of centuries of exploitation**
- **In 1969-70, the most recent normal year for Bangladesh, per capita annual income was taka 450**
- **The structure of the economy was primitive, with large-scale economy contributing a mere 6% of the GDP**
- **Nearly half the population had a deficiency in calorie intake, and the literacy rate was as low as 17%**
- **While the economy was underdeveloped to begin with, the destruction incurred in 1971 was extensive**

CHALLENGES OF NATION BUILDING

- **Agriculture sector was severely affected with immediate and substantial decline in production of rice, jute and tea**
- **The physical infrastructure of the country was in ruins with ports and major bridges out of operations**
- **In the industrial sector, the value of assets destroyed was estimated to be in millions of taka**
- **Non-measurable consequences of the war, caused by the loss of raw materials and spare parts, lack of maintenance, transfer of monetary assets, departure of a number of top managers and skilled workers, and market disruptions were immense**

CHALLENGES OF NATION BUILDING



Collapse of Hardinge Bridge span caused by bombing during the 1971 Liberation War

CHALLENGES OF NATION BUILDING

- **An overall estimate of the 1971 war might perhaps be nearer US$ 2 billion**
- **A World Bank report identified the challenges faced by independent Bangladesh:**
- ***First*, all 10 million refugees had to be returned and resettled, with appropriate relief to get them through until the first harvest**
- ***Secondly*, law and order had to be re-established – the situation aggravated by the ample supply of weapons left over from the war period**

CHALLENGES OF NATION BUILDING

- ***Thirdly*, adequate supplies of food had to be obtained and distributed through the damaged transport system, to avert the threat of famine**
- ***Fourthly*, the political and administrative structure had to be reconstituted and new institutions created to fill the gap left by the former Central government**
- ***Fifthly*, the task of reconstruction had to be commenced and the economy restored to the pre-1971 level as quickly as possible**

BANGABANDHU'S ACHIEVEMENTS

- **Despite the severe handicaps which Bangabandhu's administration faced, the record of achievements was significant**
- **Nearly all refugees were resettled and a famine averted**
- **In 1972 there was some shortfall in agricultural production, due primarily to drought but 2.27 million tons of *Aus* crop was harvested**
- **Industrial production made a fast recovery**
- **Chittagong port was cleared and all damaged big bridges, with the exception of one, were repaired**
- **Foreign exports were pushed up**

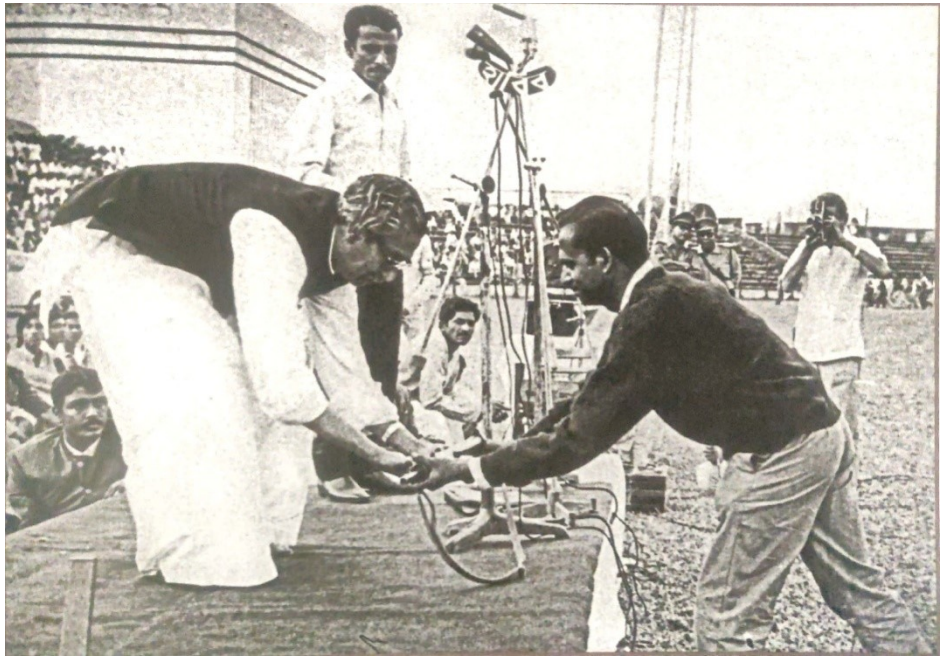
BANGABANDHU'S ACHIEVEMENTS

- **On 17 January Bangabandhu called for the surrender of arms by the Mukti Bahini within a ten-day time limit**
- **He reiterated his earlier belief that power does not come from the barrel of the gun but rather stems from the people**
- **On 24 January he went to Tangail to preside over the ceremony of surrender of arms by Kader Siddiqui (nicknamed Tiger) and his men**
- **In the next few days other groups of the Mukti Bahini surrendered their arms**

BANGABANDHU'S ACHIEVEMENTS



Bangabandhu Sheikh Mujibur Rahman greeting the people gathered at the event of Freedom Fighters' weapon submission in Dhaka Stadium (31 January 1972)



A freedom fighter submits his weapon to Bangabandhu Sheikh Mujibur Rahman at the Dhaka Stadium (31 January 1972)

BANGABANDHU'S ACHIEVEMENTS

- **Parallel to this, efforts were made to strengthen the different disciplinary forces like Police, BDR and Armed Forces**
- **Bengali soldiers replaced Indian soldiers and took up responsibility of ensuring national security**
- **Upon Bangabandhu's discussion with Indian Prime Minister Indira Gandhi, all Indian troops were withdrawn from Bangladesh by March 1972**
- **Civil administration was also slowly reinstituted**
- **Within two months district officers were appointed in all the districts and a decision was taken to upgrade the subdivisions into district**

BANGLADESH AND THE WORLD

- **Within a year of its independence, Bangladesh had been recognized by 97 countries, and had become a member of several international bodies -WHO, UNESCO, World Bank, and IMF**
- **Though it was denied membership in the U.N., the country's existence as a sovereign entity was recognized as an unchallengeable reality**
- **Bangabandhu's steadfast commitment to the Palestinian cause and Bangladesh's prompt assistance to Egypt and Syria during the 1973 Arab-Israeli war ensured diplomatic recognition by powerful Arab countries and membership of Organization of Islamic Countries (OIC) in 1974**

BANGLADESH AND THE WORLD



Bangabandhu Sheikh Mujibur Rahman addresses the Non-Aligned Movement (NAM) Summit Conference in Algeria (September 1973)



Bangabandhu Sheikh Mujibur Rahman embracing Anwar Sadat, the President of Egypt (1973)

MAKING OF THE CONSTITUTION

- **One of the great achievements of the government in its first twelve months in power was the successful completion of the task of constitution-making**
- **On 23 March the Constitution Assembly Order was promulgated**
- **On 10 April the Constituent Assembly met for two days and created a thirty-four member special committee headed by the Law Minister**

MAKING OF THE CONSTITUTION

- **The Constitution was drafted within six months**
- **The Constituent Assembly met on 12 October and it passed the constitution bill on 4 November**
- **The Constitution became effective on 16 December 1972 - exactly a year after the liberation of Bangladesh**
- **It encapsulated the four fundamental principles of the state: democracy, nationalism, secularism, and socialism**

MAKING OF THE CONSTITUTION



Bangabandhu Sheikh Mujibur Rahman speaks at the Constituent Assembly (10 April 1972)

FEATURES OF THE CONSTITUTION

- **The salient features of the 1972 Constitution included the introduction of a Westminster-type-parliamentary system**
- **Parliament was vested with supreme authority on important issues like declaration of, or participation in war, and imposing and collecting taxes**
- **It guaranteed the fundamental rights of the people and ensured the separation of the judiciary from the executive organ of the state**

FEATURES OF THE CONSTITUTION

- **The constitution incorporates a number of provisions with an eye to ensure the stability of the system**
- **Thus it stipulates that a member of parliament will lose her/his parliamentary seat when s/he loses party membership either because of resignation or expulsion from the party**
- **It also provides that the prime minister can ask the president to dissolve the parliament and seek fresh elections when a vote of no confidence is passed against him, but it does make the parliament, rather than the court, the supreme authority in the state**

AMENDMENTS TO THE CONSTITUTION

- **The Constitution (*Fourth Amendment*) Act 1975 brought major changes into the constitution. The presidential form of government was introduced in place of the parliamentary system**
- **The Constitution (*Fifth Amendment*) Act, 1979 validated all amendments, additions, modifications, substitutions and omissions made in the constitution during the period between 15 August 1975 and 9 April 1979 by the Martial Law authorities**

AMENDMENTS TO THE CONSTITUTION

- **The Constitution (*Eighth Amendment*) Act, 1988 declared, among others, that Islam shall be state religion and also decentralised the judiciary by setting up six permanent benches of the High Court Division outside Dhaka**
- **The Constitution (*Thirteenth Amendment*) Act, 1996 introduced a non-party Caretaker Government (CtG) system which, acting as an interim government, would give all possible aid and assistance to the Election Commission for holding the general election**
- **The Constitution (*Fifteenth Amendment*) Act 2011 restored secularism and freedom of religion, incorporating nationalism, socialism, democracy and secularism as the fundamental principles of the state policy**

AMENDMENTS TO THE CONSTITUTION

- **The Constitution also acknowledges the country's liberation war hero Bangabandhu Sheikh Mujibur Rahman as the Father of the Nation and incorporates the historic speech of 7 March 1971 and declaration of independence after midnight of 25 March 1971 as part of the constitution**
- **The people of Bangladesh shall be known as Bangalees as a nation and citizens of Bangladesh shall be known as Bangladeshis**
- **The Amendment scrapped the system of Caretaker Government, increased number of women reserve seats to 50 from existing 45 and inserted Articles 7(a) and 7(b) in the Constitution after Article 7 in a bid to end take over of power through extra-constitutional means**